To:
Secretary Pete Hegseth
U.S. Department of War

From:
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Regarding:
Human Control over AI usage in Military Provisions

Executive Summary
The Department of War has been rapidly expanding the use of Artificial Intelligence (AI) in military decision-making and operations. This is a strategy that poses a major threat to the country's people and legitimacy, as the effects of fully autonomous AI are not known as this technology matures. This memo details a proposal that includes amending DoD Directive 3000.09 to ban the usage of fully autonomous weapons, and creating a department-mandated certificate for any AI expansion in defense-related mechanisms.

Background/Status Quo
Throughout the history of territorial disagreements and war, different military technologies and innovations have been made to improve the effectiveness of success. The most recent development in this timeline of innovations is that of AI. One of the most prominent examples of this is through the Maven Smart System (MSS), which was used to plan over 1,000 strikes in the first 24 hours of the war in Iran[1]. Though Project Maven has been in effect since 2017, it is a specific example of how AI has transformed into something with power beyond what any other technology has been capable of thus far: it is now able to build upon itself with no human interaction needed. Many major AI companies such as Anthropic[2] and OpenAI[3] have openly released statements and spoken about this. The idea that these AI systems are constantly building on themselves without the need for human intervention is seen as a good thing, and something that should be seen as a technological innovation. Though this may make the technology much more efficient to use, it could also pose a major threat to the Department of War and the country as a whole, if oversight of this technology is not implemented. In its current state, DoD Directive

[1] Matt Mande, and Gregory C. Allen. "What Is Maven Smart System, and What Does It Do?" *CSIS*, 2 June 2026, www.csis.org/analysis/what-maven-smart-system-and-what-does-it-do.

[2] Mariana Favaro, and Jack Clark. "When AI builds itself" *Anthropic*, 18 September 2026, https://www.anthropic.com/institute/recursive-self-improvement.

[3] Jakub Pachocki. "An Alien Mind" *OpenAI,* 6 September 2026, https://openai.com/index/an-alien-mind/.

3000.09[4], the primary policy document that guidelines the usage of fully and semi autonomous weapons, places no ban on fully autonomous weapons. The document instead states that commanders and operators should exercise "appropriate levels of human judgment" when deciding upon implementation.

Importance

Though AI is considered as the next big military innovation, it differs from all the others in one major way. Smart Bombs were a military innovation that were extremely useful in the 1991 Gulf War, and many consider them to be one of the innovations that turned the U.S. military into a global superpower[5]. However, these bombs had limitations, they were less capable in adverse weather conditions, and it often took many of them to complete the task at hand[6]. This isn't an issue that AI would be stopped by, as its own technology would develop a solution without any human interaction needed. Anthropic CEO Dario Amodei has cited that there are real dangers to this development, stating that the industry has lied to people about the risks involved[7]. Amodei has been involved in conversations with the Department of War concerning these potential dangers, and how much they are willing to allow the Department to use their services for military provisions. He specifically mentioned Mass Domestic Surveillance and Fully Autonomous Weapons as things that should never be included in any agreement with the Department of War[8].

Policy Recommendations

1.) **To amend DoD Directive 3000.09 specifically using Anthropic's structure to ban the usage of fully autonomous weapons.**

The main guideline of DoD Directive 3000.09 is to set rules and regulations for the use of autonomous and semi-autonomous functions in weapon systems[9]. If the Department of War were to heed to the suggestions made in this memo, amending the directive would be the most effective way to implement this. In its current form, the directive lays out what systems it applies to, and states the proper usages of AI in defense affairs, along with responsibilities of the government to uphold this.

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[4] "DoD Directive 3000.09; Autonomy in Weapon Systems" *Department of Defense,* 25 January 2023, https://www.esd.whs.mil/portals/54/documents/dd/issuances/dodd/300009p.pdf.

[5] Warrior Maven. "The Day Stealth and Smart Bombs Turned the U.S. Military Into a Superpower" *The National Interest,* 26 May 2019, https://nationalinterest.org/blog/buzz/day-stealth-and-smart-bombs-turned-us-military-superpower-59477.

[6] "Operation Desert Storm; Evaluation of the Air Campaign", *United States General Accounting Office*, June 1997, https://www.gao.gov/assets/nsiad-97-134.pdf.

[7] Jo Ling Kent, "Anthropic CEO Dario Amodei 'For too long the industry lied' about AI risks" *CBS News,* 14 September 2026, https://www.cbsnews.com/news/anthropic-ceo-dario-amodei-on-ai-risks/.

[8] Dario Amodei, "Statement from Dario Amodei on our discussions with the Department of War" *Anthropic,* 26 February 2026, https://www.anthropic.com/news/statement-department-of-war.

[9] "DoD Directive 3000.09; Autonomy in Weapon Systems".

Anthropic's statement puts a lot of emphasis on banning the use of fully autonomous weapons[10]. This would ban the usage of weapons that are able to operate and make decisions without any human intervention at all[11]. Modern frontier AI systems, as Amodei puts it, are not yet reliable enough to fully trust in these situations, as they would pose too large of a threat to American warfighters and civilians. Since this is all relatively new technology, there isn't enough data to safely implement these fully autonomous systems, especially in such a large institution like the U.S. Department of War. If a fully autonomous system were to go rogue, not only would the safety of the general public be put at risk, the tactical effect of the system would be negative as well. This would reflect quite poorly on the United States Government as a whole.

By banning the usage of fully autonomous systems, this isn't completely doing away with autonomous systems altogether. In his statement, Amodei also puts emphasis on the success of semi autonomous weapons, specifically citing the ones supplied to Ukraine for the Russo-Ukrainian War. These systems are examples of human-in-the-loop (HITL), which can be very useful in combat and defense practices. HITL is defined as an automated system where a human is actively participating in the operation[12]. These systems can improve the reliability of automated weapons and systems, as well as improving the ethical and moral uses of them. Since a human would be helping to operate the system, it would also improve efficiency on the battlefield, since the human will always be informed of the goal of the operation. This could make tactical effectiveness increase, which would increase the success of the United States on the battlefield.

Since DoD Directive 3000.09 is an internal policy in the Department of War, you would be able to amend this without the approval of Congress. This would make the amending process much more simple and effective.

2.) **Require Department-mandated certification for any AI expansion to Defense-related mechanisms, verifying human involvement in the process.**

This certification would confirm that at least one qualified human would be involved in the developmental and organizational process of each AI-focused initiative added to the Department of War. Whether this be semi autonomous weapons or semi autonomous systems in general, a certification would ensure that the process is being overseen by humans. This certification would require clear and explicit guidelines for proposed policy. The person or persons involved in development would have to be someone with a background in computer systems that understands the risks, and how they work. When deciding what these guidelines should look like, it is important to consider the agreements that have already been made. Amodei's statement specifically states that the usage of Claude for mass domestic surveillance and fully autonomous

[10] Amodei, "Statement from Dario Amodei".

[11] Ethan J. Lee, "What are Autonomous Weapon Systems?" *Harvard Kennedy School,* 3 February 2025, https://www.belfercenter.org/what-are-autonomous-weapon-systems.

[12] Cole Stryker, "What is human-in-the-loop?" *IBM,* https://www.ibm.com/think/topics/human-in-the-loop.

weapons has never been allowed in their contracts for the Department of War[13], which is a prominent example of how guidelines like this could be implemented. By making constraints like this non-negotiable with every AI company and developer, it can create a standard set of rules for AI usage in military practices.

Since the Under Secretary of Defense for Policy is the Originating Component for DoD Directive 3000.09, they could also act as the main oversight for this certification. They would already be very familiar with the directive as a whole, meaning that their discretion for following the certification policies would be more well-informed than if another actor was to come in to fill the position. This certification would also require very explicit guidelines, meaning the discretion and personal opinions of the Under Secretary of Defense for Policy would not be an important factor. This is already a major factor of the document, as it currently lays out rules and regulations for the usage of autonomous weapons. Requiring the certification would act as an addition to this. For a better ease of passing this certification, it could apply to only future proposals for AI usage in the Department of War.

Counter Arguments

1.) "China won't slow down, so why should we?"

Many argue that because China is also rapidly developing their own AI systems for defense purposes[14], the United States should do the same. They view it as a zero sum game, where both countries having the same AI capabilities will ensure safety and protection. It is important to note that this proposal wouldn't put a ban on the development of AI systems entirely, but it would just make them more regulated and stable. This means that the Department of War can continue to operate Project Maven for defense purposes, just without the usage of certain systems. Furthermore, the usage of fully autonomous systems could increase the risk of friendly fire and danger to the United States' citizens. As previously stated, the long-term reliability of fully automated systems is still unknown, and continuing the development of these systems without considering this is very dangerous. Lastly, a potential mistake by a fully automated system could cause irreversible damages to the United States' legitimacy. This is a danger that highly outweighs any advantage AI could give, and isn't worth the risk when there is no concrete proof that these systems are trustworthy.

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[13] Amodei, "Statement from Dario Amodei".

[14] Jieruo Li, "Artificial Intelligence Technology and China's Defense System" *Air University*, 1 April 2022, https://www.airuniversity.af.edu/JIPA/Display/Article/2980879/artificial-intelligence-technology-and-chinas-defense-system/.

2.) Fully autonomous systems may improve U.S. deterrence

The other main argument against this proposal is that allowing the usage of fully autonomous systems could improve deterrence for the country. Whether it be faster response times and more thorough tactics, many think that the usage of these systems could be a helpful asset to boosting the technologies of the country and its defense system. If the Department of War is to operate on this mentality, it may create a "use or lose"[15] dynamic in battle efforts. This is the idea that as more and more actors ramp up their usage of fully autonomous systems, they will all feel the pressure to act first, making the danger of an actual attack more likely. If the United States were to put bans on fully autonomous weapons, it would lessen the effects of "use or lose". If other countries know that the Department of War isn't developing these weapons, they will feel less inclined to as well. AI may also suggest ramping up pressure to make faster attacks, which would also be incredibly dangerous for foreign stability. Mutually Assured Destruction (MAD) already ensures that an attack of large proportion is unlikely, meaning the United States should have no reason to develop these weapons for the sole purpose of improving deterrence. The country is already ranked first in the world for military strength[16], meaning the country already has incredibly strong deterrence.

Conclusion

The advancement of military technologies will never cease entirely, as the good outweighs the bad more often than not. It is important to continuously adapt and improve these technologies, as they can help to maintain the safety and security of the United States. With this in mind, it is important to also consider the threats that technologies like autonomous AI can pose, and to create set limitations and guidelines to ensure the safety of the American people, and the world as a whole. If not acted upon, it is unknown what consequences could come of fully autonomous systems as time goes on. As previously stated, this is a relatively new technology with very little long-term data. This balance is imperative to keeping the equilibrium between human stability and military dominance.

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[15] Shawn Brimley, "Offset Strategies & Warfighting Regimes" *War on the Rocks,* 15 October 2014, https://warontherocks.com/offset-strategies-warfighting-regimes/

[16] "National Rankings by Military Strength" *Military Watch Magazine,* https://globalforceindex.com/national_ranking.